TOP 5 RURAL DESTINATIONS NEAR KOLKATA

MANDARMANI

Hidden away in West Bengal's East Midnapore district, the seaside resort village of Mandarmani is slowly coming to replace Digha as Kolkata's preferred weekend beach destination. Only four hours (170 km) from the city, Mandarmani now offers visitors several water sports options—jet-skiing, parasailing, etc. Since the waves here are mostly calm, Mandarmani is also an ideal spot for swimming.

CHANDANNAGAR

In the late 1600s, the French paid the Nawab of Bengal 40,000 coins in order to make Chandannagar (then Chandernagore) their trading post. Expectedly, French influence can be found everywhere here. Walking down the Strand, the town's promenade, one sees the charming Dupleix House. Even the churches here—Sacred Heart, St Joseph's—borrow their design and stained-glass finish from France.

SANTINIKETAN

In 1888, when Debendranath Tagore set up an ashram in Santiniketan, he is said to have been taken in by the tranquillity of the town, but it was his son, Rabindranath, who realised its true potential. Visva Bharati, the gurukul-style university he set up here, still serves testimony to his forward-looking modernity. The campus is a delight to walk through. There are many bookstores and cafes here, all of which are quaint and quiet. The Sonajhuri Khoai Forest and Kopai River are only a short bike ride away.

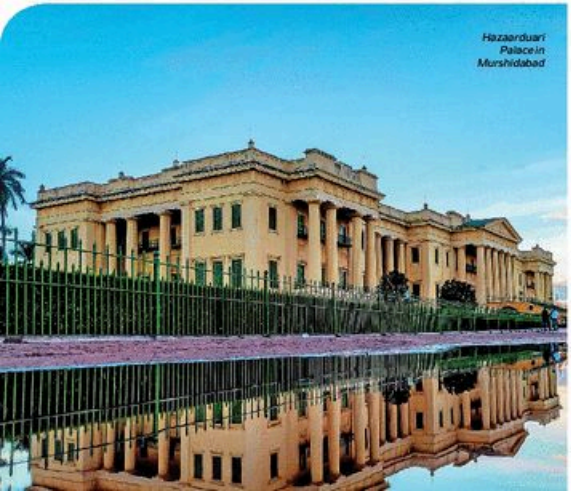
SERAMPORE

Only 24 km away from Kolkata is the quaint Serampore. A Danish colony between the years of 1755 and 1845, the town's architecture is marked by a mishmash of European influences.



Basant Utsav at Santiniketan

On the one hand, you have the colonnaded entrance of Serampore College, while on the other you have the Catholic Church with its Doric columns. The Danish Government House in the town centre is a must-see, but so is St Olav's Church. The building borrows its design and style from London's St Martin-in-the-Fields.



Hazaarduari Palace in Murshidabad

MURSHIDABAD

It was Aurangzeb, who in 1704 had declared that Murshidabad (then Muqsudabad) will be the capital of Mughal Bengal. Even though the town's prominence has diminished with time, its yesteryear glory is still apparent in Lalbagh, the centre of imperial Murshidabad. The Katra Masjid, one sees, is modelled after the Kaaba in Mecca. The Nizamat Imambara and Medina Masjid are also incredible pieces of Islamic architecture. Dedicated to Shah Jahan, Jahan Kosh is now a major attraction, but it's the museum in Hazaarduari Palace—famous for its 1,000 doors—that'll make your trip here worth it. ■